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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Friday, 27th June, 2025

The House met at 11.35 a.m.

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us vary the Order of Business and go to the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 26th June, 2025. Page 1...9?

Yes, Mr Agbana?

Mr Eric Edem Agbana: Mr Speaker, kindly permit me to take you back to page 7.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Agbana: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 5 (i) under “Recognition of Schools /Visitors” which reads “Staffs and Pupils of La/Nkwantanang...”

delete “/” and insert “-” for both the item numbered 5 (i) and (ii).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you Hon Member. Table Office, kindly take note.

Hon Members, page 9...15—

Yes, Mr Afriyie?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Thank you Mr Speaker. This is a minor error that deserves to be corrected. On page 14, the item numbered 2 (ix) under the subheading “Attendance”, the name of the Hon Member in the person of Mrs Mavis Nkansah-Boadu has been wrongly spelt. Delete “w” from “Nkwansah-Boadu”. I noticed she has not settled down yet, so I have to do this on her behalf—[*Laughter*]—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are right. Table Office, kindly take note. Page 15...22.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further correction, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 26th June, 2025 as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 18th June, 2025. Are there any corrections?

[*Pause*]

Hon Members in the absence of any corrections the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 18th June, 2025, is here by

adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members we also have *Official Report* of Thursday, 19th June, 2025 under correction. Are there any corrections?

[Pause]

Hon Members, in the absence of any corrections the *Official Report* of Thursday, 19th June, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, item numbered 6; Business Statement for the 6th week.

Yes, Chairman of the Business Committee.

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Chairman of the Business Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, the

Committee met on Thursday, 26th June, 2025 and arranged Business of the House for the Sixth Week ending Thursday, 3rd July, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers to respond to Questions asked of them during the Week:

	No. of Question(s)
Minister for Health	7
Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development	3
Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs	6
Minister for Sports and Recreation	1
Minister for Roads and Highways	10
Total Number of Questions	27

Mr Speaker, in all, five (5) Ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to twenty-seven (27) Questions during the Week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – 3
- ii. Oral – 24

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the Week and Reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the Week.

Referral at Committees

Mr Speaker the Business Committee is requesting that all Select Committees should thoroughly study the legislations establishing the various Departments and Agencies in respect of submitting Annual and Performance Report to Parliament and ensure that the Departments and Agencies report timely to Parliament for the necessary scrutiny to be conducted as part of the oversight responsibility of the Parliament.

The Business Committee has noted that there are thirty-two (32) outstanding referrals currently before the Committees. In view of this, the Business Committee is requesting all Chairpersons of Committees to take note of the backlog of referrals and report to the House. Outlined below is the list of Committees and the number of referrals pending before them:

Number of referrals

- | | |
|---|---|
| i. Finance Committee | 5 |
| ii. Public Accounts Committee | 2 |
| iii. Committee on Public Administration and State Interests | 2 |
| iv. Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies | 3 |

v. Committee on Lands and Natural Resources	2
vi. Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs	3
vii. Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs	2
viii. Committee on Youth and Sports	2
ix. Committee on Works and Housing	1
x. Committee on Roads and Transportation	2
xi. Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism	1
xii. Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions	1
xiii. Committee on Subsidiary Legislation	5
xiv. Committee on Local Government and Rural Development	1
Total Number of Referrals	32

Briefing of the House

Mr Speaker, following the Statement made by Hon Member for Lawra on Tuesday, 17th June, 2025, on the passing of seven students who drowned while crossing the Black Volta River, the Chair directed the Minister for the Interior and Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on the measures being taken to prevent the recurrence of the incident. The Business Committee has, accordingly scheduled the Ministers concerned to brief the House on Wednesday, 2nd July, 2025 on the subject matter.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216 (2) and subject to Order 67,

the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the Week.

11.45 a.m.

Tuesday, 1st July, 2025

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

Urgent Questions

(#) **Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (Nalerigu/Gambaga):** To ask the Minister for Health the status of the Disease Infection Centre in Nalerigu, started by the previous government.

Questions

***85. Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Health the novel perspective of the Ministry on preventive medicine giving the high and rising burden of non-communicable diseases.

***112. Mr Pious Kwame Nkuah (Sefwi-Akontombra):** To ask the Minister for Health why the Sefwi Akontonbra District Hospital, which was initially proposed to be 46-bed capacity, was reduced to 26-bed capacity after completion.

***127. Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (Old Tafo):** To ask the Minister for Health to provide a detailed report on the current state of the construction of the maternity ward at the Tafo Government Hospital, including when it is expected to be completed and to indicate if Government has plans to ensure its prompt completion.

***195. Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for Health the measures being implemented to address the concerns of thirty thousand (30,000) trained but unemployed health workers who are demanding posting despite critical staff shortages in health facilities across the nation.

***194. Supt Rtd Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Health when the construction of the following three (3) health centres in the Wa West District, which have been abandoned since 2017, will be

completed: (i) Gurungu (ii) Vieri (iii) Eggu

***156. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Ododiodiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Health the measures instituted to address the long-standing shortage of resident paediatricians or doctors at Princess Marie Louise Children's Hospital in Accra.

***226. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development why artisanal fisheries are not subject to a closed season to benefit spawning and increase fish stocks.

***227. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development what support has been provided to promote inland aquaculture as an alternative livelihood for displaced food crop farmers in the Fanteakwa South Constituency.

***228 Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development about the immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to sanitise Ghana's fishing sector in light of the European Union's warning that Ghana faces a potential red card.

Presentation of Papers

- a) Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana: Public Boards,

Corporations and other Statutory Institutions for the Period Ended 31st December, 2024.

- b) Report of the Auditor-General on the Accounts of District Assemblies for the Financial Year ended 31st December 2024.
- c) Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Availability of Fertilisers to Smallholder Farmers in Ghana.
- d) Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Provision and Maintenance of Toilet Facilities in Public Schools.
- e) Report of the Auditor-General on the Management and Utilisation of the District Assemblies' Common Fund (DACF) and Other Statutory Funds for the year ended 31st December, 2024.

Motions

(#) That this Honourable House adopts the Report of Leadership on the composition of the membership of the ECOWAS Parliament and the Pan African Parliament.

— (*Consequential Resolution*)

Committee sittings.

Wednesday, 2nd July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Minister for the Interior and Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on the measures being taken to prevent drowning of persons who attempt to cross the Black Volta with canoe.

Questions

***76. Mr Alhassan Umar (Zabzugu):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the total cost of the nationwide street naming and digitalization conducted.

***110. Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs when work will resume on the construction of the Youth Resource Centre at Nyinahin, the district capital.

***163. Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to provide a detailed report on the circumstances surrounding the deaths of seven Ghanaian pilgrims during the 2025 Hajj, including the specific causes, measures implemented to ensure pilgrim safety and prevent future occurrences.

***173. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodio):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for a comprehensive

update on the status of the stalled Salaga market redevelopment project.

***174. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the specific measures the Ministry is implementing to enhance fire safety infrastructure in major markets such as Rawlings Park, Timber Market, Makola market and Kantamanto market.

***193. Mr Dapaah Elvis Osei Mensah (Ahafo Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the actions the Ministry has implemented to rectify and facilitate the immediate formal commissioning of the Mankranso Methodist ICG Block, which was completed after twelve (12) years of being abandoned.

***239. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo):** To ask the Minister for Sports and recreation when work on the Nkrakan AstroTurf in Yilo Krobo will resume and be completed.

Presentation of Papers

- a) Report of the Auditor-General on the Management of Petroleum Funds for the Period January to December 2024.
- b) Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana – Public Universities and Colleges of Education for the Year Ended 31st December 2024.

c) Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana — Ministries, Departments and Other Agencies for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024.

d) Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Utilisation of GNPC's Share of the Petroleum Revenue on Infrastructure Projects.

e) Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on Computerised Financial and Electronic Systems in Selected Covered Entities as at 31st December, 2024.

Motions

Committee sittings.

Thursday, 3rd July, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work on the construction of the Otekpulu bridge in the Yilo Krobo Constituency will resume and be completed.

Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the

current state of the Bogoso-Prestea Road.

Questions

***184. Mr Seidu Alhassan Alajor (Chereponi):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following projects in the Chereponi Constituency would be completed: (i) Yendi-Chereponi-Yorku (ii) Sabuba - Chereponi (iii) Chereponi-Gbintiri.

***185. Alhaji Mumuni Muhammed Nurideen (Nalerigu/Gambaga):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the plans the Ministry has in respect of the Wundua – Langbinsi – Kasape – Busulungu – Timpela roads.

***186. Mr Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (Nalerigu/Gambaga):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the Gambaga – Nanori – Tinsungu – Latarigu – Dagbiriboari – Tamboku roads.

***188. Mr Alhassan Umar (Zabzugu):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the bridge over the Oti River at Chichagi which links Zabzugu District to Bimbilla and the Nanumba North District will be constructed.

***190. Mr Seidu Alhassan Alajor (Chereponi):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction of the Wonjuga–Wenchiki road will commence.

***201. Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah (Afigya Kwabre North):** To

ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the road network from Akon through the following communities will be completed: (i) Nkwantakese (ii) Penteng (iii) Pampatia (iv) Patase to (iv) Esaase.

***202. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads in the Trobu Constituency will be constructed and completed: (i) Asofa-Amamorley (ii) Pokuase-Katapor (iii) OmanjorDwenehon (iv) Golden Door-Yellow House (v) Agric Quarters-Abensu (vi) Ayawaso –Achiato area (vii) Afiaman Community (viii) Tantra and Capital Hill Area.

***203. Supt Rtd Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the state of the construction of the following roads: (i) Wa to Dorimon (ii) Ga to Wechiau.

Presentation of Papers

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of Nurses' Training College, Pantang for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Office of the President for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Volta Lake Transport Company Limited for the year 2024.

Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Procurement and Management of

Medical Equipment in Teaching Hospitals.

Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana (Whole-of Government Accounts) for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024.

Report of the Auditor-General on the Consolidated Statements of Foreign Exchange Receipts and Payments of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) for the Year Ended 31st December, 2024.

Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana, Pre-University Educational Institutions for the Financial Year Ended 31st December 2024.

Follow-up Report of the Auditor-General on the Three Performance Audits in respect of: Regulating Small-Scale Mining for a Sustainable Environment; Sustainability of Sports Stadia in Ghana; and Administration of Scholarships by the GETFund.

Motions

Committee sittings.

Friday, 4th July, 2025

—PUBLIC HOLIDAY (**Republic Day**)

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Business of the House has been presented. It is now for your comment.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief ?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let me thank the Majority Leader for the presentation. And start by saying that I see 27 Questions slated for the ensuing week. I am aware that, on average, we have been doing 40 to 45 Questions per week. In the face of the fact that we still have some outstanding Questions, that is for the Ministry of Transport. I am reliably informed that we have to suspend the Questions scheduled for today for a reason, Mr Speaker, I would not want to go into. Can we look at adding on to the 27 Questions because of the outstanding? That is, the Ministry of Transport and the potential Questions that would be outstanding for today, that is, the Questions scheduled for today, if the Leader of the House would take cognisance of that?

Mr Speaker, for the past three weeks or so, we have been speaking to the need for mining lease agreements, specifically, the Gold Fields Damang Mining Lease Agreement, to be brought to this House — I do not, Hon Leader, with respect, I do not — I am only doing my patriotic engagements. And the Hon Leader has agreed to this. For three weeks now, we still have not had the Gold Fields Damang Mining Lease Agreement brought to the House. What is the reason? I do not understand. This

is a constitutional call. Why is the Executive turning a blind eye? What is there? What is in that particular agreement that they cannot bring for us to assess? What is there?

I am wondering, loudly, what is in the Gold Fields Damang Mining Lease Agreement? So, I plead. I see the Majority Leader taking notes. Please take notes well. And I hope his pen is writing. Please take notes. We were expecting, at least next week, to have it brought here.

So, referencing the Business Statement, item four on referrals. I commend the Hon Leader for making space for it. However, as I do recall, the referral, back and forth between myself and the Hon Majority Chief Whip, we brought in the angle of the Ministry of Transport, because transportation on all the major water bodies in the country is under the purview of the Ministry of Transport. The Black Volta and the White Volta are under the purview of the Ministry of Transport. Now, I see specific mention of the Ministry of the Interior and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition.

Yes, the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, because the Hon Dafeamekpor had made the point that there is an exacting cause in terms of the provision of life jackets. However, we cannot take out the Ministry of Transport. It comes under their purview. So, may I suggest to the Business Committee and the Hon Majority Leader and Chairman of the Business Committee; to exercise his discretion

for us to add the Minister— We could even take out the Minister for Energy and Green Transition and rather add the Minister for Transport. I think that would be more relevant in terms of portfolios that should be called to come and brief the House. But I commend him for making space for it.

Mr Speaker, we, at least have read an official report from the University of Ghana of a limited incidence of COVID-19. The University of Ghana have had a cause to put out an official release. We do not want to dread what the country went through some time back. And so, let us make hay while the sun shines. I place this call, right in front of the respected Leader of the House, that we should make an arrangement and get the sector Minister, Hon Akandoh, to come and do the needful.

We have also read, Mr Speaker, that the Bank of Ghana (BoG) has dismissed over 100 of their staff. This is a public matter of interest. At the Committee of the Whole, it will not be out of place for the BoG boss to be here and tell us what the situation is. This is about the people of this country and it is a matter that should not be treated lightly. We have heard that the decision has been rescinded. We want to hear officially from the BoG boss at the Committee of the Whole. I have engaged the Majority Leader privately, who keeps assuring us, and I commend him. He is doing well with some of the payments.

But, Mr Speaker, I see I get your attention. The exchequer must come here. We are told he is out of the

jurisdiction, but he should be programmed to be here at the Committee of the Whole. Hon Members' morale is low. Apart from that, there are other important matters that should be dealt with. We cannot talk about them in Plenary. So, let us schedule Hon Ato Forson, one of our own. These days, he has not been coming to the House. I do not know why.

So, Mr Speaker, he should be here at the Committee of the Whole. I am not talking about Plenary. He should come to the Committee of the Whole and brief us properly so that we can deal with all these matters. I am speaking for the Majority Side. They should be nodding towards me. I see they are smiling now. Yes. This is a very popular call to the Hon Leader.

11.55 p.m.

Yes, this is a very popular call, otherwise the Majority Side would not have anybody at their back. Dr Ato Forson must be programmed to be here from Tuesday for the Committee of the Whole. The Governor of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) must come. *[Interruption]*—Well, if it is a holiday, he can come on Wednesday; we would have enough time to prepare. Mr Speaker, on the enterprise of Committee of the Whole, the Governor of BoG and the Minister for Finance must come.

Then, there is the 2.4 per cent increase in electricity tariff by the Public Utility and Regulatory Commission (PURC). Mr Speaker, if we reference page 53 of

the last Budget, it is explicitly stated there that the cost of increment in the pricing of gas, that is, the weighted average cost of gas, anticipated an increment in the international market, and it was captured and catered for in the Budget. So, the indicators are taking a nosedive. Inflation and exchange rates are going down, as they pride themselves with.

These are important indices that we use in the pricing of tariffs. Suddenly, PURC comes out and says that it is increasing electricity tariff by some 2.45 per cent. Is this the resetting agenda? So, cumulatively, it is some 14 per cent increment. I am sure Members will agree with me that the PURC boss must find his way here. We have spoken to the Governor of BoG in respect of the dismissals; we have also spoken to the Minister of Finance in respect of the payments that are so important.

Mr Speaker allow me to elucidate the point that the Minister of Finance was here and confidently said that they made payments. That, 80 per cent of District Assemblies Common Fund (DAF) payments will be sent straight to the assemblies. He said it has been sent but I have checked—I see the Majority Leader copiously taking notes. *Na sika no wo he?* To wit: “where is the money?” All the accounts of the assemblies have not been credited. Yes, they have not paid.

The assemblies and the Metropolitan, Municipal, Districts Chief Executives (MMDCEs) are crying under the reset agenda. *[Interruption]*—Backbenchers

and Frontbenchers are crying; Ministers are also crying. So, this is a matter that is of common interest. We are all crying. The irony of the matter is that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I hope you are a member of the Business Committee?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you know I have a great deal of respect for you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, are you not a member of the Business Committee?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, there is something we call an afterthought.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Sometimes I feel that as a member of the Business Committee, you must raise this at the Business Committee and ensure that your concerns are captured.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I thank you for your guidance and I am sure as we go into the future, I will be guided accordingly. But I am taking a cue from the masters of this tactics. When the Majority Leader himself was here, he was the master tactician. So, we are only learning from him.

The PURC boss should be duly scheduled, so that we will be able to deal with it. Also, we should deal with the payments. These are very critical requests. These are matters that we cannot leave out. I commend him again. On the item numbered 3, regarding the

referrals, we keep leaving these referrals to get dusty on our shelves, but he has taken the measure to bring this up and flag these matters. However, I think we can go beyond it. Stating the specific Committees and the outstanding referrals is not enough. We should mention the specific referrals. It is only then that we will be communicating to the public and also exposing the outstanding work that needs to be done.

That is only where—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: After the referrals are mentioned in this House and referred to the Committees?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: It was a decision of the Business Committee that we get the specific referrals in terms of the outstanding and I am saying that, yes, the Majority Leader has ensured that that is captured. For instance, it is stated that the Finance Committee has five outstanding and that is not enough. What is the referral? Because the numbers will not communicate in whole, but when we list the specific referrals that are outstanding, for example, a matter on Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA) or something, then we will be communicating duly to the public. Because the essence of this is to let the public know and also put the spotlight on the leadership of the Committees to ensure that these matters are dispensed with. So that is my concern.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs had said that some guidelines

had been issued in respect of the payment or the transfer of DACF, even though they have not transferred a *kobo*, not even a penny to the account.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has further gone ahead to issue quotas, that is, percentage that should be allocated to the various subject matter areas that were passed. So, Parliament passes the DACF formula, then the Minister goes ahead to issue quotas. I am not sure he is clothed with those powers. Yes, the Local Governance Act, 2016 (Act 936) gives him the mandate to issue guidelines, but it does not give him that mandate to give quotas. We are told Cabinet has taken that decision and the Minister is ferrying that decision, limiting the assemblies. That matter cannot be left unspoken about.

So, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs who is one of our own should come to the Committee of the Whole and justify why quotas were given to the assemblies. That is wrong.

Mr Speaker, these will be my initial observations and I am hoping that the respected Leader will be able to deal with these matters as he often does.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Boamah?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, I can see the Minister for Roads and Highways has been

programmed to appear before the House in the ensuing week.

Mr Speaker, I just want to bring this to your attention. I will read this to you, that:

“Statistics compiled by the Motor Transport Traffic Directorate (MTTD) of the Ghana Police Service (GPS) and analysed by the National Road Safety Authority shows that 1,207 commuters were killed between January and May this year on our highways. Motorcycles, despite carrying fewer passengers, accounted for the highest number of fatalities, killing 582 people, representing 45.9 per cent of all road deaths.”

This is a publication by the *News Centre*. This morning, I also read a piece from our former colleague for Kumbungu, Mr Ras Mubarak, who stated in his write-up that in 2024, we lost about 2,000 of our own through road traffic accidents. That is a huge number. A couple of days ago, the Minister for the Interior was here and the House graciously approved the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025, which is to be assented by His Excellency, the President, all to increase domestic tourism.

Lately, I do not know the MPs or high-ranking officials who drive on some of these highways. So, I want us to take this as a matter of urgent importance and to also ask the Minister for Roads and Highways and his

counterpart, Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari, the Hon Member for Saboba, to brief the House on the steps towards the dualisation of some of these highways;

Accra to Techiman; Accra to Aflao; Accra to Takoradi, and Accra to Elubo to improve upon our road networks and also increase the request of people to use the highways because not too many people can afford airfares. It is becoming too dangerous to lose 2,000 people through road accidents. It is a serious matter that must be looked at as a House and I call on you, Mr Speaker and, rightly so, to ask the Minister to brief us on some of these important developments.

12.05 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, my first question, I think, is supposed to be directed to the Clerks-at-the-Table but because they are unable to answer, I will direct it to the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business.

Mr Speaker, if you take our *Votes and Proceedings* of today, the one that has been approved, the item numbered 2(114) at page 3, Members present, we have Dr Forson, the Minister for Finance. Mr Speaker, I do not know, but, yesterday, we were all aware that the Minister for Finance was not in the

Chamber, so on what basis will his name be captured under “The following Hon Members were present”?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, that is why the Order Paper creates an opportunity for *Votes and Proceedings* to be corrected, and sometimes, when you notice a correction like this, all you need to do is to draw the attention of the Table Office. Now, how does that feature into the Business Statement that we are considering?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right, Mr Speaker. I will take a cue from you and move to other issues.

Mr Speaker, I have been asking these questions for the past three weeks. When are we expecting the Mid-Year Budget? This is so important because many of the Ministers in answering Questions, even the Minister for Education, said when the Mid-Year Budget is presented, some other items would be done.

The nurses whom the Committee on Health met with, for which the Majority Leader also pleaded with, needed some increment in their salaries. I am also expecting the Mid-Year Budget to create a space for them, so I would like to know from the Majority Leader when we should be expecting the Mid-Year Budget.

Mr Speaker, out of the blue, there was a midnight passage of an “e-Levy” from the Majority Side and, subsequently, we were told that its implementation had

been suspended or so. If the Majority Leader could programme the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on basis for which the implementation—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon First Deputy Minority Whip, on the issue of e-Levy, I am not aware of the passage of such Levy in this House; I am, however, aware of the Energy Sector Levies (Amendment) Act. To the extent that your question is based on e-Levy, you are completely out of order.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, to reframe, in the Eighth Parliament, we passed the Electronic Transaction Levy; that was what it was called. But our Colleagues, now on the right, abbreviated it by calling it e-Levy even though there was nothing like that. So, Energy Sector Levy—The “Energy” is also with a capital “E”. So, if I also attempt to call it Energy Sector or *Dumsor* Levy or e-Levy—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I know the abbreviation to be ESLA, rather than e-Levy.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I will take a cue and ask if the Chairman of the Business Committee could programme the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on the basis for which we are being told that the implementation of the energy sector recovery levy has been suspended and if there are plans to even completely

repeal it. Because there are serious consequences on the suspension of the levy, and if they can consider repealing it because its implementation will put a lot of burden on Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, I would like to also ask the Leader of Government Business—The President of the Republic promised Ghanaians that he was going to give us 60 Ministers; he has given us 56. If it is so that the President, within his right, wants to give us 56 Ministers, then he should amend his promise to Ghanaians.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, is that also supposed to be featured in the Business Statement?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Chairman of the Business Committee is the Leader of Government Business and Ministers and other parts—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I think my question deserves an answer: yes, or no?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: It is something of public interest and it is within his power to answer this question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I believe that this is not the time to ask questions to be answered. This is time for comments on the Business Statement.

So, on grounds of relevance, I think you are not doing justice to the issue at stake.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right, Mr Speaker; I am well guided on that.

Mr Speaker, I am aware that there is a pending Bill on the LGBTQ. I would like to know whether it has come to the attention of the Business Committee and whether such is admitted to be advertised because, Mr Speaker, what is happening in our country is very bad. Two or three days ago, we saw pictures of men kissing at the Independence Square. When they were on this Side, they advocated forcefully on the LGBTQ Bill and after getting power, they went to sleep. They no longer care about the LGBTQ Bill. They are saying absolutely nothing about LGBTQ Bill. People are kissing publicly and nothing is being done about it—*[Interruption]*—At the Independent Square, three days ago, two men—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order!

Hon Habib Iddrisu, the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill that was passed by this House but never got assented to was a Private Member's Bill. So, as a private Member, would it be wrong if you also introduced one?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am aware that there is already such a Bill and that is why I am asking whether it has come to the attention of the Business Committee and when it will be programmed.

Mr Speaker, you could see from our Colleagues, when I raised the issue about LGBTQ, they have now gone to sleep. Are they in support of LGBTQ?

Is it the case that the Government now is supporting LGBTQ? Is it the case that they are now supporting it?

Because I am raising a serious matter that, three days ago, two men were kissing at the Independence Square—*[Interruption]*—There are videos and pictures to that effect and they are pretending as if they have not seen it and Reverend Ntoso is on her feet to defend this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Habib Iddrisu, I do not want this issue to generate into a debate. Other than that, somebody may also get up to say that the LGBTQ Bill that we passed, had it been assented to, two men would not have been kissing at the Independence Square. So, let us not deviate in making comments on the Business Statement. We do not want a debate.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided and I do not want to believe that Mr Speaker has started a debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am saying that we do not want debate. It is time for comments on the Business Statement. So, if we deviate from commenting on the Business Statement to talk about issues that are not emanating from the Business Statement, we may be generating a debate in the House. That is what we should try and avoid because we all know the incidence of the LGBTQ Bill that has been passed by this House. So, please, move away from that.

12.16 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the President of the Republic, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, earlier this year, made a statement to the effect that the Government will be part of the sponsors of the LGBTQ Bill. So, to the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business, is there any indication from the Government to bring an LGBTQ Bill?

Mr Speaker, I will move away from that. The last time, the Chief Whip discussed how people were sacked from various government agencies and Ministries. We heard of about 100 workers being sacked by Bank of Ghana (BoG) and now, we are getting another information that they will be reinstated. Can the Minister for Employment and Labour Relations be programmed to answer whether there are other plans for other agencies like the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA), of which the Deputy Majority Leader is the Board Chairman, to also reinstate people who were unlawfully fired, just like what BoG did in terms of reinstating these 100 workers?

Mr Speaker, we are setting a very bad precedent in this country. If we go for national election on the 7th December and a new president is elected, we will still have the sitting President and the President-elect. So, the previous Government still has the mandate of the people, until there is a swearing-in on 7th January. So, it cannot be the case that any action taken by that government, from 8th December in an election year to

the time that the new president will be sworn in will lead to either people being dismissed or people—It is a bad precedent we are setting for the country.

So, the Majority Leader should kindly schedule the Minister for Employment and Labour Relations to brief the House about those who were dismissed and if there are plans to bring them back.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protections is here—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, is it not the case that the Minister has been here to answer Questions?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, there is a new development where BoG took a decision and it has been reversed because it might be the case that these ones too have been reversed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why the Minority Chief Whip is asking that the Governor of BoG be programmed.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, BoG is just one of the many agencies where people have been fired, so if BoG—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why the Minister you are asking to be programmed was here on a Question and answers were provided.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am being intimidated by Ms Doyoe. She was here trying to attack me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Even yesterday, the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations was here and part of the Questions posed to him was on termination of employments. Just yesterday.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Minority Chief Whip was specific that BoG should be programmed. Mine has gone beyond BoG. His is for BoG to be programmed and I am saying that there is nothing on the people who were fired from GRA. People were also dismissed from the Ministry of Health, but there is nothing on that. So, if he programmes the Minister, while BoG is reversing their appointments, these other sectors might also review their decisions of which we are not in the know. A brief to this House will confirm whether those people still have their employment terminated or they are also being reinstated.

Mr Speaker, my last point is to the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection. She answered to a Question here with regard to the termination of contracts of the caterers of the School Feeding Programme. She said that they would pay the term that they owe them but they are—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, who is your question to?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am telling the Majority Leader to programme her to brief us on the basis for which these caterers were paid by the Ministry and on what grounds is she

doing an audit to pay them again? This is because she paid them when she assumed work as the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, but, now, she has refused to pay them on the basis that she is doing another audit on the same caterers.

Mr Speaker, I would like to conclude by saying to the Majority Leader that many of the Air Conditioners (ACs) in the offices of Members are not working. Some of the floor tiles also have problems and the lift is not working. Sometimes, when we go to the lift where there is a sticker that says “MPs only”, we do not even have the opportunity to enter our own lift; it is always full. What measures has the Majority Leader put in place to address these issues?

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, I think the last one is a housekeeping matter.

Yes, Hon Jerry Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, this is flowing from what Hon Patrick Boamah had earlier intimated. He made mention of some roads, the Motor Traffic and Transport Department (MTTD) and the issue of accidents. Mr Speaker, I am looking at it from this angle: since the Minister for Energy and Green Transition is programmed to appear, I would want to find out whether we have noticed the absence of streetlights in every nook and cranny of this city.

Mr Speaker, most streetlights are not working; they are dysfunctional. I am at a loss which Ministry is even supposed to take care of that, whether it is the Ministry of Roads and Highways or the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition.

Mr Speaker, when one goes to where the President lives on the Major Mahama stretch, in the evenings, one cannot even drive and see a functional streetlight, especially around the Chain Homes area. From Burma Camp to the other Tse Addo roundabout, no streetlight is functioning. As at yesterday, from Mallam Junction to Kasoa, which is a big highway stretch, there is no streetlight working. Mr Speaker, in fact, what is even more sorrowful is that we now have gullies in the roads.

Mr Speaker, I call on the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business to programme the Minister for Energy and Green Transition and the Minister for Roads and Highways to deal with the issues of the blackouts in the city and the gullies, so that, at least, we can patch the potholes on the major highways.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to say thank you for the opportunity.

Alhaji Sayibu Suhuyini Alhassan:
Mr Speaker, I have a very simple request to make of the Majority Leader as we programme the activities to be undertaken by this House next week. But before that, I wish to comment on

the request made by my good Friend, Hon Patrick Boamah, which has also been reiterated by Hon Shaib. He requested that my boss, the Minister for Roads and Highways, be programmed to report to the House on the state of accidents in the country.

12.25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, not to take away the contribution that the state of roads make when it comes to the cause of accidents, but it is common knowledge that the state of roads is not the only contributory factor to the spate of accidents that we have in this country. So, Mr Speaker, I would rather make an appeal that a comprehensive Statement be made that will highlight all these contributory factors and possibly, if that has not been done before, the Statement is referred to a Committee to examine these causes and to enable in future an inter-ministerial committee of a sort that can work together to reduce the spate of accidents because indeed, the carnage on our roads are a worry to all of us. But I do not think that the request for the Minister for Roads and Highways alone to make a Statement on it will adequately address the problem.

Mr Speaker, as for what our Minority Whip said about LGBTQ, I am one of the sponsors of the Bill that unfortunately, though was passed by this House, could not be signed by the previous President. Mr Speaker, I want to assure him and our Colleagues on the other Side that our position on the LGBTQ has not changed one bit. We are just disappointed that our first attempt to

make it law was thwarted by the inaction of the previous Government but whenever or however the Bill returns to this House, I want to assure them that we will give it our support.

Mr Speaker, now to my request —
[*Interruption*]

Mr Speaker, one more time I want to assure our Colleagues that we in the Majority Side —

Mr Nyindam — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Matthew Nyindam, please, kindly resume your seat — [**Some Hon Members:** Sit down! Sit down!]

Alhaji Alhassan: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I just want to assure our Colleagues on the other Side that we are disappointed that our first attempt to make the LGBTQ outlawed in Ghana did not yield the desired results. If it did, perhaps the kissing at the Independence Square they are talking about would have been considered unlawful now and the people would have been arrested and punished. That notwithstanding, we are ready to consider the Bill however and whenever it is introduced into this House.

Mr Speaker, my request to the Majority Leader is in relation to the ongoing investigations that we have been reading about in the news. I will wish that the Majority Leader programmes the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, who by the way, has been doing a very good job by

addressing the press and telling people about the charges that people in the past Government are faced with. But I think it will be necessary for this House to also be briefed on the state of Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL) now. I think that the nation deserves to know. As a representative of the people, we need to know the investigations that are conducted, into what cases, which people are undergoing investigations now and when they will be going to court.

Mr Speaker, I plead with the Majority Leader to consider inviting the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice to brief us on the critical cases that are being considered now.

Thank you.

There are ECG matters and others.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nyindam, you have the floor.

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you. Mr Speaker, Order 71 clearly tells us who presents the Business to this House and when contributions are made, who is supposed to respond to those comments. But if an Hon Member gets the opportunity to also say something and he turns up responding to issues that have been raised by Members from the other Side, I think that it is not fair for us to set bad precedents on this Floor.

Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader is fully armed and he is capable to respond to Members when we raise issues. So, I

do not see why my good Friend would take the work of the Majority Leader. I do not know whether he is staging a *coup* to overthrow my good Friend. *[Laughter]*

That will not be allowed because he is more capable. We will not allow that. So please, let us all take a cue from that.

But I sincerely believe that the Majority Leader is capable. Mr Speaker, I just want your guidance on this matter so that we do not set precedents in this House where Members will ask Questions and Members from the other Side will be responding. I do not think that is the way to go because the Majority Leader has the powers and we want to take his words and not the words of other Members. Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we are all getting it wrong. After the presentation of the Business of the House, we are supposed to comment on the Business of the House. It does not give an opportunity to ask questions or debate. Order 71 is very clear and on the hindsight, if I may read:

“71 (1). Every Friday, the chairperson of the Business Committee shall present to the House, a statement on the business arranged for the following week”.

Presentation of Business arranged for the following week — for me, the essence is that the Business for the

entire period cannot be done. So, it must be programmed on weekly basis. That does not mean that a Business not slated for that week would not be done. That is why I feel we are getting it wrong. Order 71 (2) and (3) say:

(2) Where the first Sitting of a Meeting precedes a Friday, the statement on the business arranged for the remainder of the week, where possible, shall be presented on the day of the commencement of the Meeting.

(3) The chairperson of the Business Committee may present supplementary statements as determined by the Committee.

Hon Members, based on this particular Rule, what we are doing is within the ambit of the Rules. That is why I will always plead that let us all operate within the Rules and we will move forward.

Hon Members, the Business of the House, as presented is hereby adopted.

[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment is here. *[Uproar]*

Some Hon Members: Sit down! Sit down!

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us make progress with all due respect. Hon Members, we have adopted the Business of the House. Let us make progress with all due respect. Hon Members, let us move to the item numbered 7 (b).

The Minister is seated.

The Question numbered 7 (b) is standing in the name of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. You have the floor.

[Uproar]

12.35 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have the floor?

All Hon Minority Members – rose –

[The Minority Caucus rose and started singing]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly resume your seats?

[Uproar]

Please resume your seats. Let us hear the Hon Minority Leader.

[Uproar]

[The Minority Caucus continued singing]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, resume your seats. Let us hear the Hon Minority Leader?

[The Minority Caucus continued singing]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader, you have the floor?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, thank you for recognising me. Mr Speaker, I was up on my feet to draw your attention to the fact that Colleagues behind me were up to make inputs in the Business Statement. Mr Speaker, the rules of the House governing this particular exercise provides, and with your leave, I would want to quote it and read it in *extenso*. Order 71 reads:

- a) Every Friday, the chairperson of the Business Committee shall present to the House, a statement on the business arranged for the following week.
- b) Where the first Sitting of a Meeting precedes a Friday, the statement on the business arranged for the remainder of the week, where possible, shall be presented on the day of the commencement of the Meeting.
- c) The chairperson of the Business Committee may present supplementary statements as determined by the Committee.

Mr Speaker, if you peruse the document that we have before us, the

prayer of the Chair is that he is presenting what has been discussed by his Committee and when he does this presentation, Members discuss. What they do is to bring to the attention of the House some outstanding matters that perhaps the Committee could not look at. Some oversights and matters of national importance that in the opinion of Members, the Leader of Government Business ought to programme a particular Minister to address the House on.

Mr Speaker, such an important exercise on a Friday like this cannot be limited by any rule or practice. This is a House of Parliament, the people's representatives. This is the only place where they have an opportunity to air their views. It is not about a restrictive interpretation of the principle of relevance. In this Parliament, any matter discussed for the purposes of shaping governance is relevant and that is it.

Mr Speaker, Hon Members were up on their feet to bring up matters to the attention of the Leader of Government Business and the Leader of this House. Mr Speaker, I will plead with you, you are our *primus*. Once you assume that Chair, Mr Speaker, in all humility, and I say so with every modesty in me, you are not on any Side because you are the Presiding Officer and we elected you as the first among us to be there.

Mr Speaker, I will plead with you, that although you made your order that the Leader of Government Business should call for the next Business and that you have closed that chapter, please

review your decision and allow Hon Members to make their input. I came to this Chamber prepared. I have a number of issues that I have painstakingly written down to bring to the attention of the Leader of Government Business. These matters must be brought to the House for him to respond and programme whoever it is to come.

12.45 p.m.

Hon Suhuyini Alhassan rose and raised some important matters. He spoke about Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL), that he wants the Leader of Government Business to programme the Minister for Justice and Attorney-General to come here instead of holding press conferences outside. He wants him to come and address us on the state of ORAL. That is a good point. Why would he have the chance to speak and Members here will not have the chance to speak.

So Mr Speaker, I would end by saying that please, kindly allow the seven Members who were on their feet to make their point. The Leader of Government Business can respond and we can bring closure to this matter. This is all I pray.

Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, as Speakers, sometimes we are guided by decision taking at Conclave. This morning, we had a pre-Sitting Meeting and there was an agreement as to even the number of comments that are supposed to be taken.

So, Hon Members, if such decision is taken and things have changed, all you need to do is to bring it to my attention.

Hon Habib Iddrisu, we were at Conclave this morning and some agreements have been reached. So why are we going to do the contrary, as if it is the Speaker who is taking a unilateral decision?

Hon Majority Leader, Hon Minority Leader—No, I am not calling you to be on your feet, but I am drawing your attention to the fact that certain things that happen here would emanate from some arrangements that we have reached at Conclave. So, when those arrangements are reached, I have a difficulty agreeing to do “A”, then I will come and sit down here to do “B”. That is a challenge that I have at hand. We have even already agreed as to the number of Questions to be taken.

Majority Leader, I will give you the floor first.

Mr Ayariga: Let me plead with Hon Colleagues that we should allow this one to pass. It is an appeal I am making to all of us. We have all agreed among ourselves that on Fridays, we will do some small politics. That is a common understanding. There is nothing in our rules that provide for that, but we agree to relax the rules and erase all sort of issues on Fridays. We make semi-statements under the guise of drawing attention to matters that should be on the Agenda, and we joke and laugh, then we proceed.

Let me appeal to Hon Members. I know that they do not feel happy about how the process has been truncated today. But this morning, we had agreed that because today is Friday and we intend to always close early on Fridays so that we can start departing early to our constituencies, we should not go beyond 2.00 p.m.

That was what we had agreed among ourselves. I remember that when we were having a banter about it, one of us in this Chamber told the Speaker that it will be the Speaker’s responsibility to manage the time and make sure that we actually operate within the 2.00 p.m. rule. When we were leaving the Conclave, that person also made it very clear that the discussions that took place never took place. I have not mentioned Hon Habib Iddrisu’s name.

Why is he laughing as if he is the one I am talking about? But there was an agreement to do our usual Friday politics and then we can—In fact, we even agreed that there should be no Questions so that we can close early, but we should allow Members to do their usual Friday politics. That is why as the Minority Side went on, I never tried to interrupt or restrain anybody.

So, I am pleading with my Colleague, the Minority Leader, that the protest has been adequately registered. We can take that on board next Friday in the way that we manage Business Statements. So, it is a plea. He can ask his Question. In fact, we did not want to ask Questions, but because the Question has been asked by no less a person than you, the

Minority Leader, we insisted that we will make an exception for your Question, so that we can close early.

But my plea is that let us let sleeping dogs lie and let us proceed with Business as indicated by Mr Speaker. This is an appeal to my Friends on the other Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Like our able Majority Leader was saying, I was at Conclave this morning with the Majority Leader, your good self and the Clerks-at-the-Table. Yes, we agreed to some other issues, but we never agreed that when Business Statement is presented and Members raise questions, the Majority Leader or the Chairman must not respond.

Mr Speaker, as much as we want to assist you to manage this House, we will not assist you to set a bad precedent with the Business Statement. The Majority Leader is a sixth time Member of Parliament, and in my small years of being in Parliament, I have never seen even one occasion—Unless a Member does not raise any issue.

Mr Speaker, if Business Statements are presented and Members raise concerns, they need to be responded to. Serious questions were asked. Normally on the Parliamentary calendar, we call this Sitting the mid-year Budget Sitting. I have asked questions on it, no response. The Minority Chief Whip has

asked serious questions, no response. So, Mr Speaker, is it the case that he will present the Business Statement, we raise questions, but get no response at all. Mr Speaker will just raise issues and make a commentary, but will not say anything.

Mr Speaker, I agree that we agree on other things, but that has been violated even by your action. Because if we said there was not going to be questions like the Majority Leader said—When you said the Business Statement is adopted and the next item is Questions—Where is the bad faith coming from?

So, Mr Speaker, with respect, I think that *Hansard* will capture what happened today, and it should not be captured that the Business Statement was presented, Members raised concerns and questions, and got no response. Then, the Speaker just vetoed that it is adopted.

So, Mr Speaker, with respect, let him respond to our questions, and then after that, if there are concerns from Members—Because we never discussed at Conclave that when concerns are raised, he will not respond, or we should truncate any Business Statement process.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Habib Iddrisu, honestly speaking, the issues raised —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have heard the plea from the Leader of

the House. I think we can make some compromises. Ten of them were up. We can agree to take five of them, because they keep approaching me. The Ranking Member for Trade, Industry and Tourism, and the Member for Nalerigu/Gambaga also have some issues. So, let us take the limited five, just to assist the Majority Side, so that the Leader of Government Business can come and respond, and then after that, we can take their questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, we are to take five more. I want to be guided by the sense of the House.

12.55 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: My plea is that, even if one's father errs, they do not give their father up in the marketplace. So, my plea is that my Hon Colleagues on the other Side would accept the ruling of Mr Speaker today. As they can see, the ruling affects them and it also affects me. The ruling affects me because we know the practice—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, we are masters of our own rules; if you are amenable to taking five additional comments on the Business Statement, I do not mind.

Mr Ayariga: Well, Mr Speaker, if you do not mind, then I do not have problem.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, a number of us, about five people, have already raised questions. Can he respond before they go on to ask other questions?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let us take all.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right—**[Some Hon Members of the Majority: No]**—Mr Speaker, the application is to you, but I do not know why they are saying no. They do not have the power to make that decision. The one who has the power is the one I am addressing and I do not know why they are just saying that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Baafi Okyere, you have the floor.

Mr Michael Baafi Okyere: Mr Speaker, I just want to draw the attention of the Hon Majority Leader to a very critical situation that has happened within this country that needs to be addressed as soon as possible. I am talking about the abolition of the One District, One Factory (1D1F) policy of Government—*[Interruption]*—Excuse me, sir; please, let me finish. I believe seriously that this policy was doing so well in this country, especially when we had about 165 active companies operating within this country that would not have a very good anticipation in the future—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member—

Mr Okyere: I just want to come to my point and it is just a preamble to what I want to say—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us make some distinction here. There is a distinction between Business Statement and Statement under Order 93. When it is Statement time under Order 93, then you can get up to raise a matter of urgent public importance. But this one is a Business Statement governed by Order 71. So, if it is a comment on the Business Statement, then that one can be taken. But this one—Your issue is on the 1D1F.

Mr Okyere: Mr Speaker, I just wanted to ask the Hon Majority Leader to programme the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, if possible, next week, for that the Minister to bring to the House an alternative to the 1D1F programme. Because there is no alternative now. It was only announced in the Budget that they would like to bring a policy they call “Feed the Industry”. But we have not received any substantive arrangements and elaboration on the policy. So, if the Minister can come to the House to give us a brief next week, it would be very appropriate. That is all I want to say in the Business Statement for next week.

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni: Mr Speaker, there is a very important issue that has come up some a few days ago and I was expecting the Business Committee, chaired by my senior Brother, to factor it in this Statement and get the Minister for

Health to the Chamber to update the House as to what the issue is. What then is the issue here? Some few days ago, the University of Ghana issued a statement about COVID-19, banning all social gatherings—*[Interruption]*—Who has raised the issue? Mr Speaker, nobody has raised the issue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that was the very issue raised by the Hon Minority Chief Whip, Mr Frank Annoh-Dompseh.

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, because of the importance and the immediacy of the issue, that is why I am trying to echo what the Hon Minority Chief Whip said. Mr Speaker, if we look at this issue, it is a very important and we need to get the Minister for Health to respond and update the country as to whether COVID-19 is back or not.

Mr Speaker, yesterday, I went for a programme in the evening. At the programme, what I got there, everybody was wearing nose masks. So, this issue is bringing fear—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you want the Minister for Health to be programmed?

Alhaji Mumuni: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei: Mr Speaker, I would take the Hon Majority Leader to paragraph 4 of the Business Statement. In paragraph 4, the Business schedule is a briefing to the House and then the Hon Majority Leader is scheduling the Ministers who are

affected by this Statement read by the Hon Member for Lawra, concerning the students who passed on the Black Volta.

Mr Speaker, when we refer to *Hansard* for the day, when that Statement was read, it would be recalled that our able Minority Chief Whip commented on the Statement and he called for the Minister for Roads and Highways as well, if possible, to brief the House about this issue. Then that was followed by Hon Dafeamekpor who had also raised issues with the Volta River Authority (VRA) and National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO) and for that reason, we indicated that the Minister for the Interior should also appear.

Mr Speaker, that took us to include the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to also come, but, in the Business Statement, we realised that it is only the Ministers who were raised by the Majority who are appearing before the House. So, I thought it would be proper if the issue of the Minister for Roads and Highways can be added, so that we can take this matter once and for all. Otherwise, we would be dealing with it in piecemeal and that would also take time of the House. So, I would want to draw the attention of the Majority Leader, so that, if it is possible, the officers from NADMO—That is what I want to draw the attention of the Majority Leader to.

Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah: Mr Speaker, I want to draw the attention of the Hon Majority Leader to the threats made by the Ghana Registered Nurses

and Midwives' Association (GRNMA) yesterday. There are efforts made by the Committee on Health to get the Association to suspend its strike action.

Yesterday, they expressed disappointment at the fact that we have not been able to meet their needs as promised. So, I thought the Hon Majority Leader could arrange for the Minister for Health to appear before us and brief us on efforts made to ensure that the nurses cancel the strike as it is altogether.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further comment?

1.05 p.m.

Osahene Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me, on behalf of my Hon Colleagues, thank you for your magnanimity in helping them to air their views.

We pray that such engagement shall continue for the peace of this House. We may proceed.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, on the question of mining leases, let me assure Members that I will continue to push for the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to present to this House the various mining leases that are outstanding and need to be ratified by this House.

I have, in all sincerity, agreed with all of us in this House that we must have the mining leases in this House. It is an accountability mechanism because we get to see the terms of the lease, monitor and ensure that the leases are implemented according to the terms. So, it is not appropriate that these leases do not come to this House, but this did not start today. In the last several decades, many mines have operated without their leases coming to this House for ratification. It is not right and we must stop it.

Mr Speaker, COVID-19 incidents were raised earlier. I have seen the statement of the Ghana Health Service (GHS) and it is very clear in its terms. It says that the World Health Organization (WHO) no longer treats COVID-19 as a health emergency. It does not mean that COVID-19 has ended. Once in a while, there will be sporadic recurrence of infections in some places, but it is not a threat. Indeed, the Ghana Health Service says that nobody has been admitted on account of having COVID-19, but they still encourage people who experience the symptoms to report, so that they can be taken care of.

I believe the vaccinations have gone very far and there has been a huge coverage in terms of vaccinations. Many of us have developed the capacity to resist and if infected, to be able to survive when given treatment. So, let us take advantage, but the Ghana Health Service does not consider it to be a serious health emergency that should attract the kind of interventions that are being advocated.

On the issue of the Common Fund and the guidelines which was raised earlier, yes, it is the guidelines that have provisions that assign quotas in terms of how much money should go for what items. I think that they were not issued by the Minister for Finance. I have a copy of the guidelines and they were issued by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

The Act clearly makes provision for the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to issue the guidelines. I have seen a copy signed by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, Hon Ahmed Ibrahim; so, they were not issued by the Minister for Finance.

Essentially, the guidelines say that 25 per cent of the funds should be spent on the design and construction of 24-hour model markets. So, spend the money on the construction of a market. It is our women, our mothers and sisters, who sit under the sun in our villages, communities and towns to sell.

And the Minister has insisted that 25 per cent of the money be spent on constructing markets, so that our women can have decent places to sit and engage in the economic activities that enable them to pay our fees for us to be here today and to pay for medical bills that have enabled us to survive till today. So, we are prioritising our markets, market women, our mothers and sisters. That is the focus; prioritise them. That is what the guideline says.

I do not know if there is a problem with insisting that we should prioritise our women because they are the chief beneficiaries of the construction of the markets. An allocation of 10 per cent should go to health facilities for health care and another 10 per cent to educational facilities. Look at the young ones sitting up there, they are here because we have given them good education; 10 per cent should go to education. This House can debate it. We can express our reservations, but are we saying that education is not a priority and that the guideline that says to focus on education is wrong? Is that the issue?

Mr Speaker, it says that 10 per cent of the money should go to water. We need potable water for our villages and communities. So, the guideline is directing the assemblies to pay attention to water.

Another 5 per cent for administration, including monitoring and evaluation activities. Again, 10 per cent for solid and liquid waste management. These are essentially the guidelines. These are what we call quotas. I do not know if they disagree with it.

What else do they want the money to be spent on? The travel expenses of District Chief Executives (DCEs) and Municipal Chief Executives (MCEs)? Because we do not want a situation where the resources go to the districts and are not applied to address the welfare and the concerns of ordinary citizens. That is why we are insisting on these guidelines and the quotas that have been allocated. Clearly, the law makes

provision for the Minister to provide for these guidelines and he has accordingly done so.

Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC) and the tariff adjustments. They have called on us to invite PURC, but I think that it is the Minister for Energy and Green Transition that we should invite to come and brief the House. So, we will make arrangements for the Minister to come. When he comes, do not complain about the politicisation of the energy sector because we all know that the whole of last year, and I think sometime before that, there was an effort to prevent the PURC from adjusting the tariffs. So, that whole period, there was no adjustment, but we know very well that bills were accruing and payments have to be made. The Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) is accumulating huge debts and it has to be paid for.

Who is supposed to pay? Is it not the consumer? If we are not adjusting the tariffs to enable ECG to pay, ECG is going to collapse. They are no longer going to be able to buy the inputs needed to keep the generators on and we are going to have the lights off. The bills have to be paid. So, if PURC is doing its work, I do not think that there is a basis for saying that because we have improved the economy, the exchange rate is stable, the dollar rate is stable and inflation is relatively stable, if all these indicators are stable, it does not mean that the debt that has been accrued at ECG will just be wished away. The debt has to be paid. It has to be paid partly by consumers.

We have designed a model for paying the debt. That was why we came in here and appealed to the House to approve the adjustments to the Energy Levy, so that we can have GHC1 saved from the benefits accruing from the decreasing price of fuel at the ex-pump price to pay that bill, so that we can have ECG to function efficiently in addition to the privatisation of the distribution subsector of the energy sector. So, these are measures that are being put in place to address the huge debt that has accumulated at ECG. The Minister will be invited. He will come and give us the full details of the mess that we are in and the effort that we have put in place to address that mess.

1.15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I think the other issues that were raised were on road accidents. Yes, I think that the Minister for Transport will be here next week, so, we have just added to the list of items that he will address. Mid-Year Budget, yes, it will definitely come. The Minister is out of the jurisdiction. When he gets back, I believe he will put things in order to come and present the Mid-Year Budget. It is a statutory requirement.

The Minister will come and brief us on why the levy was suspended.

But basically, the levy was passed on the understanding that, if it will lead to an increase in ex-pump prices, it will not be enforced. We made the promise clear that the reason the levy was passed is to harvest the benefits of the decrease in petroleum prices at the pump. So, if we

see that some global developments will create a situation where there will be an increase, we will not enforce the law. We do not want to impose hardship—this is not a government that takes pride in imposing hardship. Wherever we notice that hardship will be occasioned to Ghanaians, we will do whatever it takes to ameliorate it.

So, when missiles were flying between Iran and Israel and global oil prices were increasing and we saw some indications that ex-pump prices might increase as a result, we decided to hold on with the implementation of the legislation because we do not want drivers to pay more than they have to pay. This is the explanation for the suspension but the Minister will come and add his voice to the explanation.

On Lesbians, Gay, Bisexual Transgender, Queer (LGBTQ), this Side of the House remains committed to make sure that LGBTQ is not part of the culture of this country. We are very clear on that. We laboured to pass a legislation on the matter and the former President refused to sign it. I am surprised that my Colleagues on that Side, at that time, we did not hear their voices on the refusal of the President to sign it.

Suddenly, they have found their voices and want to pretend that they are the chief advocates of anti-LGBTQ matters in this country. When it mattered most to fight the menace, where were they? When they were the Majority and ruling Government, where were they?

Mr Speaker, there was an issue about street lighting. I think the Minister is distributing street lights to Members of Parliament to enable Members of Parliament—*[Interruption]*— it is across the board. Even our Side has not received them yet. So, it is going to come and then everybody will get it. So, I want to assure Hon Members that they will be getting street lights. It may not be enough, but we can focus on the priority areas.

On the One District One Factory (1D1F) abolition, let me indicate that it has always been part of the laws of this country for industries to enjoy tax exemptions under certain conditions. All industries located in the Free Zones enjoy tax exemptions. The One District One Factory was a policy to encourage the establishment of at least one factory in every district.

Mr Speaker, if after nine years, we come to this House and we plead for factories to get tax exemptions under 1D1F, it is shameful. Shameful because we are telling the world that after nine years, we could not establish at least one factory in each district under the tax exemption scheme. After nine years, at least you should be able to account for the One District One Factory across the country. After nine years, we do not have one district, one factory, and yet Hon Members are still in this Chamber appealing to this Side of the House and this new Government to continue 1D1F.

So clearly, the policy has failed and if after nine years we cannot implement the policy, why should we continue

along those lines? But Members should not worry, we are bringing a comprehensive policy on the 24-Hour Economy, and the 24-Hour Economy has, at its core, a programme for a revolutionary transformation of this country through rapid industrialisation. That will happen, and where there will be a need for tax exemptions, we will come to this House and ask for the tax exemptions.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of the registered nurses, the President directed that a meeting be convened by the relevant Ministers to address the concerns of the nurses. I was there when he gave the directive, because I went to report the work that Parliament did in terms of mediating to get the nurses to call off the strike and the promises that Parliament made to the nurses, and he directed that a meeting be held with him to see how far we can go in terms of meeting the needs of the nurses.

Unfortunately, the Ministers are all out of town as indicated on radio yesterday by the Ranking Member for the Committee on Health. The Minister for Finance and the Minister for Health are all out with the President in Brussels on a major health issue. So, when they come back, I will follow up and ensure that that meeting to address the concerns of the registered nurses, as promised by Parliament, takes place so that we see how far we can reach out to the nurses. I believe the issues have been addressed. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

1.25 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Leader has attempted. It was a good attempt to deal with the issues well enough. I will refer the Leader to Order 79. In fact, if my wish was to call for the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to be programmed, I would have said so. The PURC is an independent constitutional body, and I am saying that, to the extent that our new Orders allow Independent Constitutional Bodies to come and address us and deal with issues at the Committee of the Whole, that is my preference. So, Leader, get it right. We do not want the Minister for Energy and Green Transition; we want the Executive Secretary of PURC to come to the Committee of the Whole and address the issues.

Mr Speaker, if you may permit me, the Leader attempted as usual to do his own thing. But the indicators are clear. Inflation, exchange rates, and weighted average cost of gas at the international level are the key indicators for the pricing of tariffs. All these indicators have taken a nosedive and to the extent that these indicators have taken a nosedive, he has questions to answer.

I appreciate the Leader for settling on the Minister but we want the Executive Secretary of PURC to be here at the Committee of the Whole. The Majority Leader also left out the employment concerns at the BoG. Leader is diligent but he is human so I am just bringing it to his notice. I know it is inadvertent, so the Governor of the BoG should also

come to the Committee of the Whole; that is important.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude on this note. I have heard the argument, and it is the two sides of the coin, that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has the mandate under the Local Governance Act, to issue guidelines; I am not contesting that. I am saying, Mr Speaker, from 1992 or in the 80s when we started practising the Local Governance system, there has never been a time that Parliament passes a DACF formula. We pass the formula, and then the Minister goes to issue quotas that are at variance to the formula.

To that extent, the Minister has to come to this House and speak to the representatives of the people on what is engineering this? To the extent that that explanation has not been given, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs must come to this House and explain to the people's representative where he is drawing his powers from. We have the mandate and Cabinet cannot overturn a decision by Parliament. When we pass the DACF formula, it is the Local Government's responsibility to ensure its enforcement.

When we pass the DACF formula, it is the responsibility of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to ensure its enforcement. You can issue guidelines but the guidelines will not be at variance and that is the point. So, you are giving

sanitation 20 per cent and market 10 per cent. What was the original formula that was approved by this House?

Mr Speaker, in concluding, the Leader will again do his own thing, he should not turn the people against us. We are for markets; We are for AstroTurf. He should reference to the formula that was approved; GH¢70 million was devoted for the construction of AstroTurf. The new formula that was approved by the DACF— GH¢70 million was dedicated to the construction of AstroTurfs, markets, parks; it has already been taking care of. So, questions about duplication— Duplication of function in which way? Make reference to the past DACF formula.

So that is the point and I want the Leader to take this in good stride. I respect him, I know he is a listening Leader but where we are making mistakes, it is our responsibility to bring the matters up to him. The Governor of the Bank of Ghana cannot just sit at the comfort of his office and be dismissing Ghanaians just like that. He must come here. And the Minister for Finance— he forgot to speak to it. So if the Leader can take those into consideration –

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, with all due respect, because I owe a fidelity to the rules, if you look at Order 79 that you mentioned, it says that:

“A Question asked of the Head of an Independent Constitutional

Body shall be responded to at Committee of the Whole.”

That is when you pose a question, you know as Members of Parliament we are entitled to ask any Independent Constitutional Body Questions. We are entitled to ask any Minister Questions. It is following the Question that the Minister or the Head of the Independent Constitutional Body will be programmed on the Business Statement to appear before the House.

But where there is no Question directed at the Independent Constitutional Body, where there is no Question directed to the Minister, or there is no Statement transmitted to the Minister, and then at a time for adoption of the Business Statement, we are saying bring the Minister or bring the Independent Constitutional Body to come and answer the Question. The issue then is that which Question have we filed in relation to which the Minister should be programmed to come and respond to. That is one aspect that we should look at.

Two, Independent Constitutional Bodies are defined at Page 4, the Interpretation Column which is Order 6 of the Standing Orders. With your indulgence if I may read,

“Independent Constitutional Bodies” include Electoral Commission, Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice, National Commission for Civic Education, National Media Commission, Office of the

Administrator of the District Assemblies' Common Fund, Office of the Auditor-General, Bank of Ghana and other bodies established to have exclusive jurisdiction in the performance of assigned functions.”

Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC), is it also an Independent Constitutional Body? This is just food for thought. We should think around it, and mine is to bring it to your attention then we can have a best way of going about the issues. Whether we should raise Questions directed at them to come and answer, or how do we go about it, or can the Business Committee *suo motu* programme them to appear before the House and respond to Questions? What Questions would be transmitted to them to come and answer? These are issues that we should take on board in commenting on a Business Statement. I am to provide a guide.

Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: With respect, Mr Speaker, and I thank you for your cherished guidance.

Mr Speaker, I will not attempt to regularise or put logic on the guidance you have given, but I recall vividly—I am one person who follows the Business of the House with keenness. Mr Speaker, two months ago, the Bank of Ghana (BoG) boss was programmed to come to the Committee of the Whole to brief the House on certain infrastructures that the Bank of Ghana

had invested in. Mr Speaker, the call was at the instance of a concern that was raised at the Business Committee; it was not a specific Question that was filed. So, if precedence is anything to go by, my preference is for the PURC's Executive Secretary to come here. Mr Speaker, I think if you read the latter part of the Interpretation Section, it says;

“...Office of the Auditor-General, Bank of Ghana and other bodies established to have exclusive jurisdiction in the performance of assigned functions”.

Mr Speaker, with respect, I know and I respect that the interpretation of these rules lies in your bosom. If it is your pleasure that as was suggested by the Majority Leader, it should rather be the Minister for Energy and Green Transition coming to address this matter, so be it. But I insist that I am within the provisions of the Orders that we should rather allow—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, by the application of the *ejusdem generis* rule as to whether PURC will also be an Independent Constitutional Body, because the Constitution expressly mentions those bodies but that may be—

Yes, Hon Member?

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I commend the Majority Leader and the Leader of Government Business.

Mr Speaker, the Attorney General is the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader pleaded for five people. You granted his plea and gave five people the opportunity and we responded. He does not have to be satisfied with my response. It is because we are being nice to each other.

The Speaker is indirectly telling the Hon Minority Chief Whip that if he wants a Minister to come and answer a Question, he should file a Question either Urgent Question or Oral Question and the Ministers will come. If he wants an Independent Constitutional Body to come and answer Questions, he should file a Question. If he wants an issue raised on the floor, he should come by way of a Statement. He can even move a Motion that we can debate on and pass a consequential Resolution. The rules are very clear, but like I said, we have all agreed to play our Friday politics and disperse, but let us not carry it too far.

Please, Mr Speaker, the Minister has been sitting here; It is almost time for Friday prayers and Members of Parliament have to travel to their constituencies. We have Questions and then we have two Statements to make. So, I am pleading with them we cannot use three to four hours every morning just to deliberate on Business Statement, something that your own Committee has met, deliberated and concluded on and we are simply just reporting. So, Mr

Speaker, let us end it there and let us get to Question time.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We will certainly end it there, but the Leader has a responsibility. A while ago, he just forgot about Finance and I brought it to his attention. A while ago, he forgot about BoG and I brought it up. So, we are not just doing politics, we are representing our constituencies and he must take this in good stride.

We respect the Leader, but we are also representing our constituencies; the Minister should wait. This is Parliament; we cannot please the Minister. The Minister must wait and answer the Questions. This is the Parliament of Ghana; He must wait.

[Mr Speaker Gavels]

1.35 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I have not said they should not represent their constituencies; I have not. I encourage them to represent their constituencies, and I encourage them to do it properly. They should ask the necessary and urgent questions.

I have checked with the Governor of the Central Bank on the issue of the so-called terminations. They are not terminations; they were people who were recruited in the dying days of the administration of the previous governor, and they were taken on a six-month probation. It has come to the end of the probation period, and the person who has put them on probation does not think

they should continue. If a person fails a probation, the agency is entitled to not permanently engage them, and so he decided not to continue. But upon pleas and interventions, he has extended their probation by another six months to give them an additional opportunity to prove themselves. Those are the facts, I just checked.

So, Mr Speaker, those are the issues, and they are rightly pointed out. The reason I cautioned and said let us have the Minister is that I looked at the rules, and I saw that PURC is really not an independent constitutional body, so we cannot start giving them access to the Committee of the Whole to answer Questions. We have to pass the Questions through the Minister, that was why I said we would rather invite the Minister. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Some Hon Members — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minority Leader?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I am sorry, Leader. Just a minute. Mr Speaker, it is alright that he puts matters in context. I disagree with a few, but in essence, we can make progress. So now, the takeaways are essential; Minister for Finance and BoG. It does not lie in his mouth, with respect to the Majority Leader, to tell us that the BoG boss is putting somebody on a six-month probation. Let him come to this august House and answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us look at the item

numbered 4 on the Business Statement at page 2.

“Mr Speaker, following the Statement made by the Hon Member for Lawra, on Tuesday, 17th June, 2025, on the passing of seven students who drowned while crossing the Black Volta River, the Chair directed Minister for the Interior and Minister for Energy and Green Transition to brief the House on the measures being taken...”

So, you realise that these Ministers are being programmed to come and brief the House following a Statement that was made. In the same way, following a Question that you have filed, Ministers will be programmed in the Business Statement to come and answer those Questions. So, if you do not have a Question and there is no Statement, we cannot just assume that the Business Committee is supposed to programme Ministers to come and appear before us. To do what? It is either to respond to Questions or there are issues raised based on which the Business Committee will programme them to come and respond.

But for independent constitutional bodies, they cannot even come here and make Statements on their own, just like how Ministers have it under Order 91. So definitely, they will pass through the Leadership to be given the opportunity at the Committee of the Whole. But for us, we have the tool, so we can use the tool to bring them to the House to come and respond to our Questions or address

our issues that we have raised in form of a Statement or a Motion debated and there is a consequential directive to the Ministers. So, Hon Members, with all due respect, the tools are available for us; let us take advantage of them according to the Rules and Business Committee will programme them accordingly.

We have spent so much time on the Business Statement; can we now adopt the Business Statement?

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I had caught your attention and I was proceeding when the Majority Leader respectfully rose. Mr Speaker, notwithstanding the agreement—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us hear it; what is your issue?

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is the chief defender of human rights. This week, the suspended Chief Justice complained of breach of her right to fair hearing. I think that the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice should be programmed to come to this House, to respond to us as to how he is ensuring that the right of the Chief Justice to fair hearing is protected. Mr Speaker, we are supposed to protect human rights.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly file a Question directed at the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice?

Nana Baffour-Awuah: Mr Speaker, very respectfully —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You may file a Question. The Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, based on your Question, will come and address the House.

Nana Baffour-Awuah: Mr Speaker, are we saying that, irrespective of the absence of Question, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice cannot be programmed to come to this House, very respectfully, to address this House on an all-important issue about the breach of the Chief Justice's right to fair hearing? Mr Speaker, if this House cannot protect the right of the Chief Justice to fair hearing, then we are all in trouble.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly resume your seat.

Hon Members, the Business Statement as presented is hereby adopted.

Hon Members, let me acknowledge the presence of Odorkor SDA School. They are led by Mr Otchere Eugene-Wisdom, a teacher, and they are from Ablekuma North. They are 44 in number.

[Pupils of Odorkor SDA School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Grace Life International School. Edem Wilson-Mensah is the teacher, and they are from La Nkwantanang.

[Pupils of Grace Life International School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have Asankran Oda Methodist Basic School, led by Stanley Kwaku Buah, headmaster. They are from Amenfi West and they are 82 in number.

[Pupils of Asankran Oda Methodist Basic School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: On behalf of Parliament, I wish you a fruitful stay.

Hon Members, let us move to the item numbered 7(b), Urgent Questions.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3) and have the authorisation of Osahen Afenyo-Markin to ask the Minister for Youth Development —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please proceed to ask the Question.

Ms Kyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

URGENT QUESTION

MINISTRY OF YOUTH DEVELOPMENT AND EMPOWERMENT

Measures to Complete Youth Resource Centres in Dormaa Ahenkro, Dunkwa-on-Offin, Axim and Ho

Ms Shirley Kyei on behalf of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker,

I beg to ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment what specific measures the Ministry is undertaking to complete the four outstanding Youth Resource Centres in Dormaa Ahenkro, Dunkwa-on-Offin, Axim, and Ho, and when these centres are expected to be fully completed or operational?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

1.45 p.m.

Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment (Mr George Opare-Addo): Thank you, Mr Speaker. The National Youth Authority, in 2018, began the construction of 10 multi-purpose Youth Resource Centres in the then 10 regions of Ghana. The project was designed to combine recreational facilities to attract the youth to a one-stop centre for congregation and development.

The objectives were to enhance youth development by encouraging the youth to acquire lifelong skills, sharpen their talents, and provide entrepreneurship training to be able to make valuable contributions towards national development.

Mr Speaker, the construction of each project was in two phases: phase one and phase two. The works of Phase One included the construction of spectator stands, Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) standard football pitch, eight-lane-running tracks, tennis courts, handball, and

volleyball courts as well, including additional amenities.

The design also provided spaces under the stands for indoor games, changing rooms for competing teams, offices for youth development training and counselling, an ICT centre, a restaurant, and a gymnasium. Phase Two included external fencing, inner perimeter fencing, security gates, ticketing booths, pavements, lawns, and storm drains. The Authority was financing these projects through the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF). However, untimely release of the funds, coupled with continuous reduction of the 5 per cent of the DACF, as instructed by the National Youth Authority (NYA) Act, 2016 (Act 939), has been the major setback towards the completion of these projects.

The percentage of the DACF received by the Authority has fallen to less than 1 per cent of the 5 per cent that the law requires them to be given and the last time they received anything substantial was in 2023. The NYA has not received full allocations of funds, covering over six quarters. This has greatly impacted the ability of NYA to proceed with the completion of the 10 regional resource centres. The Authority is indebted to its contractors, forcing them to abandon the various sites, while some have taken the Authority to court.

Mr Speaker, by December 2024, construction stood at the following percentages at the various places that the Hon Member wants to know. In Dormaa Ahenkro, 75 per cent of the work has

been completed. In Dunkwa-on-Offin, 85 per cent of the work has been completed. In Axim, 87 per cent of work has been completed and in Ho, 85 per cent has been completed.

Mr Speaker, the following are the outstanding works at each of the sites. Dormaa Ahenkro in the Bono Region, plumbing work is partially completed. Electrical works is partially completed and the multi-purpose course, that is for handball and basketball, is partially completed. Construction of the perimeter fence wall is partially completed; ticketing booth is partially completed. Inner perimeter fence is partially completed; access roads, parking and walkways are partially completed.

In Dunkwa-on-Offin, eight-lane-running tracks and concrete base are partially completed; painting, plumbing and electrical fittings are partially completed. Multi-purpose courts, handball and basketball courts are partially completed.

In Axim, in the Western Region, multi-purpose courts are partially completed; installation of floodlights is partially completed. Spectator car park and walkways are partially completed and external works, that is pavements, gutters and the lawns, are also partially completed.

In Ho, the multi-purpose courts are partially completed. The ticketing booth and gates are partially completed.

Mr Speaker, the construction of the Youth Resource Centres in the regions remain a laudable idea. However, the lack of funds to honour the payments have seriously delayed this completion. The Ministry wishes to assure the Hon Member and this House that all efforts are being made for the release of funds from the DACF and upon the timely release of the funds by the Administrator to the Authority, the projects will be fully completed for the benefits of the youth in Dormaa Ahenkro, Dunkwa-on-Offin, Axim and Ho, respectively.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, is there a revised timeline for the completion and commissioning of each of the centres and what is being done to adhere to this timeline?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, like I said, it is purely based on releases of funds to the Authority. We have engaged the contractors; they are willing to go back to site once we are able to pay the outstanding certificates that have been raised. If one looks at the percentage of works that are outstanding, the one that is even low is the one in Dormaa Ahenkro, which is 75 per cent of work totally completed.

For Dunkwa-on-Offin, we have 15 per cent of the work to be done; in Axim, 13 per cent and then in Ho, another 15 per cent. So, once money is released and then we are able to pay the outstanding certificates, we believe

strongly that, within the shortest possible time, the work will be completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, it did not sound like we have a definite plan of completing the resource centres. Can we be given a definite timeline? I did not quite catch that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I think this question has been answered that when releases are made.

Ms Kyei: Does he have any idea when the releases will be made?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Minister, do you have an idea as to when the releases will be made?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, based on our conversations with the Administrator, he has assured us that, within the shortest possible time, releases will be made.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, can the Minister let us know when the shortest possible time is?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the question?

Ms Kyei: I would like to know if he can let us know when the shortest possible time is.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well — Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, I believe strongly that when the Administrator says the shortest possible time, he means the shortest possible time. As to when the release will come, I will not be able to say, but he has assured us that the money will be released within the shortest possible time.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, can the Minister let us know if he has entered into any partnership with private sectors or any development aid partners to finish these Resource Centres?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, as it stands now, these projects are under contracts and they have been contracted to contractors. So, the National Youth Authority has not engaged any private sector to complete these projects. The source of funding for these projects are the District Assemblies Common Fund, so, once the money is released to the National Youth Authority, the contractors, who have been legally given the job to do, will go back to site and complete it, but we have not given any private person any contracts.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you exhausted your supplementary question?

Ms Kyei: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister — I think he has underscored the fact that they are very important projects that have to commence and it is important that we are assured of where the funding is. He has spoken about the fact that it is a District Assemblies Common Fund. Is it the one that has been assigned to the various districts or is it coming out of some other sources within the DACF?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, the National Youth Authority, 2016 (Act 939) allocates 5 percent of the DACF to NYA. My understanding is that, over the years, there have been challenges with the release of the fund. Instead of 5 per cent going to NYA, within the last few years, it has continuously been reduced. Within the last six quarters, NYA is given less than 1 per cent of the 5 per cent that the law requires should be given to them.

So, for the Hon Member's answer, the money is supposed to come from parts of the DACF. That is what the law says.

1.55 p.m.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I am happy that the Hon Minister has indicated that the law says that a certain percentage must be assigned to that but of late, they are not meeting it. But I understand they are resetting the country and he is supposed to make sure that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minority Leader, the Hon

Minister did not say “off late”, he said, in the past, they were given 1 per cent contrary to the law.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, yes, that is why I am asking. Even if it is in the past, we have not been able to meet the required percentage for the whole thing. Now, we are resetting, so I expected the Hon Minister to come out clearly that this time around, with the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF), the Administrator has been able to assign the exact percentage to make sure that the Hon Minister will be able to complete his projects. I did not get that clear indication. Can I get an assurance that since they are resetting, we would get him to advance the funding to ensure that the project is completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it the Common Fund Administrator or the Hon Minister?

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, the Common Fund Administrator because he has been handling it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, I believe strongly that the formula for the Common Fund is done by this august House. So, my plea to this House is that going forward, when the formula is being developed, the allocations that are for youth development, not just the National Youth Authority (NYA) but the Youth Employment Agency (YEA) because issues that affect young people are so critical, let us endeavour to make

sure that that allocation is made and it is only this House that can make sure that happens.

We will continue to engage with the Administrator of the Common Fund to make sure that what is due the NYA is given them, but the formula comes from this House. So, please, going forward, we expect that Hon Members will help us, so that what is due the NYA and other youth development agencies are given them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, is the Hon Minister saying that the youth resource centres in Dormaa Ahenkro, Dunkwa-On-Offin, Axim and Ho would all be equipped with ICT labs, entrepreneurship hubs and vocational facilities? If so, when and what are the specifications we are looking at?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, as part of the contract I inherited, that is what the contract document says and it is part of what the contractors are supposed to do. They are supposed to build ICT centres as part of it. The ones that have been completed have all the centres. So, the understanding is that the remaining seven that are yet to be completed would also have the centres included.

The entrepreneurship hubs are run by organisations, so once it is completed, we will have the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP) taking over those

centres to run entrepreneurship programmes. Then the NYA will run the ICT centres to give the needed skills to our young people.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the indication was that today being Friday, we should close early. So, at conclave, it was agreed that we take one supplementary question each, because we have four Statements to take. So, Hon Members, I am amenable. If what has been agreed upon at conclave will not work, I can take so many supplementary questions as possible.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am not opposed to that, except that I thought you would indulge me, just because I am in leadership, to ask one additional question. But I am also amenable and that is subject to your approval.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, you have the floor.

Mr Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I just want to find out from the Hon Minister if they have put some monitoring and evaluation mechanisms in place to ensure that the intended purpose or objective of these projects are delivered and there is also the value for money bit of it. That at all times material, we would have some value for money.

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, I want to assure the Hon Member that that has been done and assurances are of the

highest order. It will happen when the centres are completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, do we move to the Question numbered 7(c) which stands in the name of Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz, Member of Parliament for Savelugu?

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, again, I come under Order 88(3). I have authorisation from the Hon Member to ask the Question on her behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, do.

Measures instituted to ensure sustainability of NSPs trained in Agribusiness and Cocoa Farming

Ms Shirley Kyei on behalf of Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz (NPP—Savelugu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment the measures instituted to ensure that National Service Personnel trained in agribusiness and cocoa farming receive post-training support, including land access, logistics or markets to ensure sustainability.

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, under the renewed and expanded mandate of the National Service Authority and in line with this overarching strategic transformation agenda, the Authority has instituted a comprehensive youth in agriculture and agribusiness programme aimed at repositioning graduates and community youth.

This programme goes beyond conventional training models. It is designed as an integrated end-to-end framework that nurtures young agripreneurs from the foundational stage of technical and vocational skills acquisition through practical field-based deployment to enterprise establishment and market integration. The programme combines theoretical instructions with hands-on training in various agricultural disciplines, including crop production, livestock rearing, post-harvest management, value addition, agribusiness development and digital agriculture.

The Authority is partnering with key stakeholders such as the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, Ghana Cocoa Board, Tree Crops Development Authority (TCDA), the World Food Programme (WFP), Agri-Impact Group and the Mastercard Foundation under the HAPPY Programme to ensure that these young farmers are supported with structured post-training interventions. These include access to land, starter kits, mechanisation services, logistics, micro-grants, input supplies, mentorship, corporate information and market linkages.

Mr Speaker, the National Service Authority wishes to assure the honourable House that we have put in place right measures to provide post-service support to the beneficiaries of the sustainable programmes and initiatives. The Authority has secured 20,000 acres of land in Kumawu and plans to acquire an additional 30,000 acres to promote clustered farming for

efficiency. National Service personnel and beneficiaries will be paired with experienced cocoa farmers for shared resources and mentorship under the Cocoa Expansion Model Initiative.

Mr Speaker, the interventions of the agro-processing hubs have also been planned to set rural centres for value addition and market accessibility. The Authority is also facilitating the registration of young farmer cooperatives among trained National Service personnel through the farmer cooperatives to enable them harness the benefits of cooperation. These groups will receive technical support from the Department of Co-operatives and the Ghana Enterprises Agency and will be linked to input suppliers and banks for group-based financing and to also serve as off-takers for government institutional markets.

Mr Speaker, today's world is moving at a high pace in the digital world. Therefore, the digital platform will pilot a tech-driven extension and e-market place system, offering agronomic advice, price transparency and real-time support. This technology will also help in the Cocoa Youth Innovation Challenge to enable the production of healthy cocoas that are free from pests and other diseases.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry, through its monitoring and evaluation and other technical services, will support the Authority to transition over 100,000 trained youth into sustainable agriculture and cocoa enterprise within

four years and significantly, boost national food security and cocoa output.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

2.05 p.m.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, can the Minister assist the House with figures of personnel that have been trained to date?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, do you have the figure readily available?

Mr Opare-Addo: No.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You see, Hon Members, that is the difficulty. I think we must come to an understanding that when a Question is posed, it is for a stated reason, that is why Order 89(1) says that the follow-up must stem from the Question. It is to avoid taking the Minister by surprise. Because the Question requires the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment to talk about measures instituted to ensure that National Service personnel trained in Agribusiness and cocoa farming receive post-training support.

This has nothing to do with the total number of the people trained. The Question is on receiving support, but the supplementary question is on what the total number is.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, I think when we decide to train a number of people,

we put figures to the number. So, I think it can emanate from this question, because we do not randomly pick people and not keep records of the people we are training.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister, what is your response?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, I do not have the figure readily available, but I can provide it to this House at a subsequent date.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, are you done with your supplementary question?

Ms Kyei: Yes, Mr Speaker. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from the Hon Minister that since he has taken over the Ministry, what concrete plans are in place by way of this post-training support to help those that they have trained as of today?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Currently, it is a new programme that is being run, and like I have said in my response, we have made allocations. We have acquired lands that we intend to give to those who are

currently participating in the programme.

My Director for National Service informed me that he has had serious engagements with the Colleges of Agriculture that are responsible for most of these students and they are locating lands in Kumawu for them as cooperatives. They are also supporting them through a training programme that is being led by MasterCard. It is when they exit that we will be able to give them the needed support that we are talking about.

The lands have been secured as I speak to you. When they finish, they would be put into cooperatives of five with lands given to them and then the needed support in terms of fertilisers, seedlings, and other things given to them. Government, through the Ministry of Food and Agriculture is also establishing the Agriculture Mechanisation Centres which they will leverage to support them to plough their lands and other supports that they need to be given to them. So some support will be given once they exit the programme.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from the Hon Minister if he has any idea at all the acreage of land that has been acquired for these purposes, and where, apart from Kumawu.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, in my Statement, I said that we have acquired 20,000 acres in Kumawu, and we are in the process of acquiring another 30,000. We are yet to acquire that land.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Leader?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister whether he has sighted the land that he is speaking about, because he is making an assurance that he has that plan already. Has he sighted it and is he sure of the acreage that he is talking about?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which one? Is it the 20,000 acres or the 30,000 acres?

Ms Appiagyei: I think the Minister gave —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because 20,000 acres has already been acquired.

Ms Appiagyei: Yes, but I am asking whether he has been there to — It is a programme that he is undertaking and he is giving the House an assurance that these lands have been acquired.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No.

Ms Appiagyei: The ones that have been acquired, and the ones that he — whether he sighted them and he can give

us the assurance that they are all in place.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you sighted them?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, with the 20,000 acres in Kumawu, it was in my handing over notes. I have not seen the land with my own eyes, because I have not been to Kumawu yet. But I know there is work ongoing on that land currently and at least per the records, the land is in existence. We are yet to acquire the 30,000 we spoke of, so I cannot stand here and say I have seen the land, because it has not been acquired yet.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, can I go ahead with my question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you can go ahead.

Ms Appiagyei: I want to find out from the Minister, how much was put into it? Since it is in his handing over notes, how much was deployed into acquiring these lands and whether that amount has been fully paid?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leader, with all due respect, are we not going contrary to Order 89? Because the Question under reference is the support service to personnel trained in Agribusiness.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, my question is emanating from the Answer that the Minister gave, because once he is giving an insight, —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He was honest to say that for the 20,000 acres, it was acquired before him.

Ms Appiagyei: Yes, Mr Speaker, rightly so. But he mentioned that it is in the handing over notes, so it will be a matter of interest if the Minister can give us some information which will be very much appreciated.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, unfortunately, I do not have the figure here, but I can furnish this House with the amount later.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nyindam?

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Minister said they have acquired some lands. May I find out from him under what conditions they acquired those lands?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, do you want to ask the condition of the one being acquired now or the condition under which the previous one was acquired?

Mr Nyindam: The one previously acquired and the one he is acquiring now, because he is inheriting the lands. According to him, handing over notes has been given to him and as a Minister, he should supervise fully and have control.

2.15 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, owing fidelity to the law, the Question is, the support being given to personnel trained in Agribusiness.

That is what the Question is about, including their access to land, logistics and market to ensure sustainability. But your question is the condition based on which a land is acquired. How is it emanating from the question asked?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if you would permit me to assist. Mr Speaker, the Order upon which a supplementary question is mounted is Order 89(1). We are all learning and with your permission I quote:

“As soon as a Question is answered, any Member, beginning with the Member who asked the Question may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification on any matter of fact on the answer...”

Mr Speaker, emphasis on “on their answer”. The Minister in his answer made mention of land acquisition. Therefore, a supplementary question can be to demand clarification on how the land is acquired. It does not mean that when a question is asked Members cannot go outside of it. I agree with you that, when you are asking the question itself, everything else must be within.

However, if the Minister in his own answer provides some information—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, which Order did you read?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I read Order 89(1) and I would read it again and with your permission I repeat:

“As soon as a Question is answered, any Member, beginning with the Member who asked the Question, may without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the answer...”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, conclude it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, and it further says and I read:

“...but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question”.

Mr Speaker, take it easy. You can only ask a supplementary question based on the answer given you. Without an answer, you cannot ask a supplementary question. Therefore, it is my humble submission that to the extent that a Minister of State, in answering a question, provides an answer, which answer perhaps even go outside of the main Question, a supplementary question could lie in for the one asking.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I would give you an example. Yesterday, for instance; the Hon Minister for Education was here to answer a

Question. He himself preceded his answer with a matter unrelated to the subject matter. And you may recall that I even got up to ask you how we treat the issue. And you said I should wait and come under a supplementary question.

Mr Speaker, so I am saying that, yes, we should comply with the rules, but these are the bare facts. If you talked about land acquisition, and a Member is saying that since you talked about land acquisition, you should share with us or clarify how the land was acquired—Again, if a Member is talking about how training is done, and you say, some people are being trained, a supplementary question can be to demand how many, because you are saying they are being trained. If I demand to know how many, it would not be a new question. It is emanating from the main answer.

Mr Speaker, I beg to submit accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader.

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I think, standing on the same Order 89(1) that Hon Minority Leader read, it does say that the supplementary question shall not introduce any matter not included in the original question. What is being asked here is neither in the answer he gave nor the original question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect,

part of the answer is that 20 acres of land had already been acquired before he was even appointed as a Minister. And here lies a Minister—He is asking a supplementary question on what conditions those lands were acquired before he came. So, before you walked in, I was finding out from the questioner, whether he was talking about the land acquired before he came, or the one that they are in the process of acquiring.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I am surprised we are debating this matter. Just like you and the Minority Leader have read Order 89(1), and the Deputy Majority Leader from the Other Side also read it, Mr Speaker, this is what the Question says:

“To ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment the measures instituted to ensure that National Service Personnel trained in agribusiness, cocoa farming, receive post-training support, including land access, land access, logistics, or market to ensure sustainability”

Mr Speaker, that is the Question, and then in answering, he himself admitted that he came and some 20 acres of land had been acquired. That is how he answered. But I am surprised that as a Minister, he took office and 20 acres of land has been acquired, he inherited it, and he is not even interested about the conditions. I would be surprised.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Nyindam, with all due respect, if the

Question posed to the Minister is the conditions under which the 20 acres of land was acquired, the Minister would have prepared the answer to come and give. But when you pose a Question regarding support to the National Service Personnel trained, and now you are asking him under what condition was those lands acquired, Hon Members, let us be fair to all manner of people, you understand?

And I will repeat that the essence of this Rule is to avoid taking a Minister by surprise. Do you not think that if you are a Minister and a Question is posed to you that under what condition were the National Service lands acquired, you would have prepared your answer to come and give, rather than if they ask you what support you are giving to the National Service Personnel trained in agribusiness?

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, if I were the Minister, I would know how to answer. But I am not the Minister. According to the Question, there is an access of land. If the Minister is not prepared to provide that answer, like I said, it is up to him. But there is an aspect that talks about access of land. So, assuming today you sent your trained people there and then something comes up, how are you going to handle it? So, Mr Speaker, I am not sure that I am putting my Minister under pressure. I am not seeing it because he is so happy. He is laughing and I am sure that he will do the needful. Mr Speaker, access is there and I will be very happy if he can—Granted that for the 20 acres, he cannot talk about the conditions.

Mr Speaker, he also told us that he is acquiring some other lands. So, may I know the conditions under which he is acquiring those lands?

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That was the clarification I was seeking. Hon Minister, the land you are in the process of acquiring, based on which conditions are you acquiring those lands?

Mr Opare-Addo: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The 30,000 acres that we intend to acquire, we are still doing the feasibility. So, once we are done, I will provide the answer to all the questions.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, our respected Minister of State, in responding to Ms Abdul Aziz Fatahiya, the Member for Savelugu, tells us that some National Service Personnel are being trained and MasterCard Foundation is bearing part of the costs of all these arrangements.

Mr Speaker, may I know from our respected Minister; these trainings that he is talking about, how many National Service personnel are benefiting from this training so far? You said there are trainings. Some people are being trained and MasterCard Foundation is also playing a key role in supporting that initiative, which we already know. Share with us how many National Service personnel, from your own

answer, under the circumstances, are being trained.

2.25 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, like I stated earlier, I did not expect to be asked for numbers and figures of people who were being trained under this programme, so I do not exactly have the number here, but I can provide the House with those numbers subsequently. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, to be fair, since he admits that indeed, he has provided us with information regarding training, but he does not immediately have the numbers, I think as he is seeking your leave, you may grant him leave, so that at a later date, he can provide us with the numbers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leave is hereby granted, but this question has even been asked and answered.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker, that is all right.

Mr Speaker, our respected Minister of State also tells us about the involvement of MasterCard in this whole exercise. May I know from him, the extent of funding for this by MasterCard?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, from what I gathered from the notes that were left for me, MasterCard signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the National Service Authority to provide US\$12 million in total funding over a stated period. This programme preceded the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government's coming into office. The programme is currently ongoing. It is in its second year, and some funds have already been expended. MasterCard does not work directly with government agencies. They work through vendors, and from the last check, I know that at least they have released funding for last year, a year before last year, and currently, this year. They are also in the process of releasing funds to the vendors so that they, in turn, run the programme with the National Service.

The total amount for the period of five years is US\$12 million, but as of this afternoon, I will not be able to say how much has been totally released. But I know that two years ago and last year, about US\$4 to US\$5 million was released to the vendors. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I appreciate the Hon Minister's sincerity.

Mr Speaker, in view of his answer, may we grant him leave to provide us with the specifics? He is talking about US\$4 million, but he also admitted that he is not too sure. But figures are figures. This is a house of records. So, Mr Speaker, if leave may be granted him, so that at a later date, he can share with us the exact records.

That said, Mr Speaker, the main crux of this question or the heart of this question is, the empowerment measures being instituted for our National Service personnel. In the Hon Minister's view, and considering the unemployment situation, especially when our youth are done with their National Service and they walk around looking for jobs, which becomes difficult, how does he hope to use this training programme? Because it is a whole investment. How does he hope to use this programme to create a retainer for the personnel and tap into the entrepreneurial skills to enable them to pursue such a programme long after their service?

Mr Opare-Addo: Mr Speaker, like I said in my response to the question, what we are doing with the National Service personnel is to give them the right training and the needed entrepreneurship support that they require. It is our hope and prayer that once they exit the programme, they will build on the skills we have given them. We are also using the Ghana cooperatives to support them in forming cooperatives, so that they can leverage that to start their own line of businesses.

The National Service Authority, together with the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, is willing to provide them with the necessary support in terms of seedlings and land. The 30,000 acres that we intend to acquire are to support them, because land acquisition has always been a major problem. So we intend to build land banks to support those who want to venture into commercial farming, but then we are

going to give it to them in terms of cooperatives. So, we will give it to five or ten of them coming together.

We are also training them in digital skills so that they can leverage that for digital marketing. So based on the training we are giving them, we believe strongly that that should propel them to go on their own and the needed support they get, they can use that to expand or build their businesses. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will proceed with my last for my respected Friend and Minister.

Mr Speaker, with all that our Minister has shared with us at his last submission at the dispatch box, he tells us that the support to even help the service personnel post service is aimed basically at helping them to build capacity and to have jobs. Now, there is no denying the fact that these interventions come at a cost to the state. A form of social intervention? We know the history of social interventions in Ghana. Investment from the Government to the vulnerable who do not pay back becomes costly. So, the state—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I will always remind you of Order 88(7).

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Rightly so, Mr Speaker.

We know the challenge we have. People benefit from social intervention and they now see that as a freebie.

Instead of paying back for others to benefit, they do not pay, which we know. In those days when the Ministry of Trade and Industry had guarantees, Ghanaians benefited, but they would not pay. And the Government of Ghana had to pay. They take loans from the Microfinance and Small Loans Centre (MASLOC), but they do not pay. It becomes a cost. It becomes a burden on the state. They take from Outboard Motors, but they do not pay. They take farm inputs and they do not pay. It becomes a burden on the state.

Now, considering this huge investment the Ministry is going to make, what measures are they putting in place to create some safeguards where they can be assured that these youth who want to go into commercial farming, digital training, and who have been given some capital, once they become independent, can pay back to enable others also benefit from same, so that the capital invested becomes a revolving capital?

Mr Opare-Addo: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The programme is in two folds. We have the one that is being supported by the various donors, including MasterCard. And we also have what the Government is supporting them with. What the Government is supporting them with is the land that the Government intends to acquire, so that they can form cooperatives.

There is going to be a land bank that the Government is going to give to

them. The reason we are encouraging them to go into cooperatives when they farm is to get people to off-take whatever they are producing, and then once it is bought, the Government can now retrieve whatever support is given to them. So, yes, we have put in place measures that are going to address and ensure that this does not become a freebie.

The second phase of the programme is what the donors are supporting them with. That is the capacity building, and then some of the skills training that they are giving them. They are not going to pay those back because it is in a form of support from donors that is going directly to them. But the support the Government is giving to them is what we intend to use in their cooperatives. That is why we are asking them to form cooperatives, and whatever support we give them, once we give them our land and they are farming, and once they harvest, and the off-taker buys the goods, part of it will go to settle —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, kindly allow the Minister.

Mr Opare-Addo: I am Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment of Ghana, not for a particular party. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am done, but I have seen the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry and her Deputy. The Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry and her Deputy are finally here. Today

that they have not been programmed, they are here.

2.35 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, we thank you so much for attending upon the House to answer Questions slated for you. You are hereby discharged.

Yes, Hon Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry?

Mrs Ofosu-Adjare: Mr Speaker, I am here because I am available. The Minority Leader knows very well that, any time I have not travelled on behalf of the country looking for investors to invest here and representing Ghana on the international scene, I am always here to do Business. I am here to also draw the attention of Table Office to the fact that I am here to answer Questions that Members have put at my Ministry, so that we help address all these things in our reset agenda.

I thank the Minority Leader for recognising my Deputy and me in the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, do you want to have the floor on this again?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, no, the truth of the matter is that she has not received her releases. Her Ministry has not received its releases; she should deny.

Mr Speaker, this is a house of records and this is an allegation, so she should speak into the microphone and confirm whether or not she has had her releases for 2025. She should tell us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, I will not allow you to chart that path.

Mrs Ofosu-Adjare: Mr Speaker, I am extremely grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Deputy Majority Leader, there is an Order Paper *Addendum*; what do we do?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, yes, I want to pray that we look at the Order Paper *Addendum*. The Minister is here to obviously lay the Paper.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, as for the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, this is not a matter for her. It is a matter for the Frontbench.

Mr Speaker, the practice is that the Frontbench must always consult. They have brought an Order Paper *Addendum* without any prior engagement and they are saying that we should allow this; that is no problem. Since this the Social Protection Bill is an important one, we will support it. But in opposition, they spoke against the LGBTQ. When would the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection bring the anti-LGBTQ Bill that they spoke so much about? They said they would deal with it. Today, the Hon Minister is bringing the

Social Protection Bill; when would she bring that Bill to us?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, that is why you are not in charge of Government Business.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is so; I am now in opposition. I agree, but they made a promise to the people of Ghana. They promised that they would not allow people to do certain things at the Independence Square. Today, we are seeing that and Ghanaians are concerned. Where is the law? They said they are doing consultation. The President promised the Catholic Bishops that they were doing consultation; that was in January.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: We are in June. Mr Speaker, I am not in charge of Government Business, but I have to remind them

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, I have always advised that matters of this nature will provoke debate. So, for now, let us veer away from it.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, my Hon Brother is quite interesting this afternoon. It looks as if my Hon Brother and his party think differently when they go into opposition. I pray that they stay there.

Mr Speaker, as my Hon Brother has agreed that the Minister go ahead and lay the Paper, I pray that the Minister is allowed to do so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at Commencement of Public Business, Order Paper *Addendum* – Presentation and First Reading of Bills.

BILL — FIRST READING

Social Protection Bill, 2025

AN ACT to promote access to Social Protection, provide social protection services to specified persons, establish and specify institutional arrangements to secure social protection and provide for related matters.

Presented by the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Ms Agnes Naa Momo Lartey). Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Four Statements have been scheduled for today.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I think we have been here for a while and that you said earlier that, today being Friday, you intend that we close early.

I am just praying to move a Motion that we adjourn the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but I said so within a context that we agreed

at the pre-Sitting to truncate Businesses, so that we could accommodate some Statements because we have about 50 Statements. But if the view of the House is that the House should be adjourned, then before you move the Motion, let me acknowledge the presence of students from John Hopkins University Bloom Collectives, USA. They are led by Prof Tanay Lynnhams. They are from Essikado-Ketan. They are from the constituency of Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah and they numbered 22.

On behalf of the House, may I humbly welcome you to the Parliament of Ghana. May you have a fruitful visit.

[Students of John Hopkins University Bloom Collectives were acknowledged]

Prof Ayensu-Danquah: Mr Speaker, unfortunately, I was listening to the Minority Leader and he misled me. I apologise.

Mr Speaker, they are from John Hopkins University. They are all medical residents trying to train for Obstetrics and Gynaecology. They have been in Ghana working on behalf of the university and John Hopkins University is also my alma mater. I did my Masters in Public Health in John Hopkins. They are here to visit us and to see Ghana and I think— *[Interruptions]*—Mr Speaker I also like to welcome them to Ghana and commend them for the good work they are doing for Ghana.

Mr Speaker, thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members Motion moved, any seconder?

2.45 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me acknowledge the industry of our respected Colleague, the Member for Essikadu-Ketan; she is quite new in this House and not many people can achieve this feat: to go back to your *alma mater*, facilitate some students coming here to do their residency or some further training and they are training as obstetricians and gynecologists. Mr Speaker, what our Colleague has done deserves commendation—*[Hear! Hear!]*—And I commend her for doing such because, in the medical field, we know of the deficits.

Mr Speaker, let me also commend the professor who led his students to fly all the way to Ghana to stay with us and to relate—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, our guests who are staying with the local people and providing them with medical support as part of the training, let me commend them highly. It is not easy to even choose our part of the world from where they are coming from; if we compare, they are well-placed. So, the essence of their profession is service to humanity and they must have the passion to be able to do it.

Mr Speaker, my parents wanted me to read Medicine, but I did not have the heart for it and I said I would read Law. But I am proud to say that my son is reading Medicine—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Yes, he is in his third year in medical

school, so, at least, he has embraced this very important profession where they save lives.

I wish them many accomplishments. They have brought a hard-working fellow to us in this Chamber. We pray that this reset Government would find a good use for her profession because she is a very experienced professional and I wish her well although she borrowed the seat.

Mr Speaker, without more, let me thank you for your magnanimity and I second the Motion for adjournment if it has been moved.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved and seconded and it is for the consideration of the House. The Question, therefore, is, as many as are in

favour of the Motion adjournment say “Aye”—

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we are just clarifying the time that it is 2 p.m. on Tuesday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the House is adjourned to Tuesday—

Hon Members, is Tuesday not a Holiday—[**Some Hon Members:** No]—Very well. We just passed the Bill.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 2:51 p.m. till Tuesday, 1st July, 2025, at 2.00 p.m.

